CARMILLA

BY GRACE DARLING

A reimaging of the novella by Josef Sheridan Le Fanu.

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SYNOPSIS: In 1872 in the remote forests of Styria, Austria, the play follows Laura, a lonely young woman whose secluded life is upended when a mysterious woman arrives at her home after a carriage accident.

C H A R A C T E R S

*YOUNG LAURA / LAURA. 19-25. Naïve, curious, and empathetic. She yearns for a life beyond the isolation of her home. Has the personality of that homeschooled girl you knew growing up.

CARMILLA KARNSTEIN. 25-40. Enigmatic, manipulative, and deeply conflicted. Her charm and allure are her tools for hunting. Hides a deep, centuries-old loneliness.

FATHER. 40s-60s. LAURA's father. Overbearing and contributes to LAURA's loneliness, though unintentionally. He fears losing her.

MADAME PERRODON. 30s-60s. LAURA's governess. Close to the family. Kind and motherly.

LAFONTAINE. 30s-50s. FATHER and LAURA's housemaid.

THE COUNTESS. 40s-70s. Supposed mother of CARMILLA.

DOCTOR SPIELSDORF. 40s-60s. The driving force behind the revelation of CARMILLA's true nature.

PEDDLER. 20s-60s. Snake-oil salesman. Sells charms supposedly to protect against vampires.

V O I C E O V E R O N L Y

WOMAN'S VOICE. Any age. LAURA's deceased mother. Speaks to LAURA in her dream.

*The same actor will portray both YOUNG LAURA and LAURA.

S E T T I N G

An old, isolated castle *(schloss)* in the countryside of Styria, Austria.

T I M E P E R I O D

1872

P R O N O U N C I A T I O N S

CARMILLA. CAR-mill-ah

STYRIA. STEER-ee-ah

PERRADON. PAIR-ah-don

LAFONTAINE. lah-fawn-TAIN

SPIELSDORF. SPHEELS-dorf

BERTHE. BEAR-tah

KARNSTEIN. KARN-steen

FRAULEIN. FROY-line

MIRCALLA. MER-cal-uh

MILLARCA. MILL-arc-ah

OUPIRE. OH-pyre

C O N T E N T D I S C L O S U R E S

Horror. Sexual content. Blood. Toxic relationships. Period-typical homophobia. Death.

SCENE ONE
AN EARLY FRIGHT

*[*AT RISE: YOUNG LAURA's *bedroom. There is a small bed and a bedside table with a candelabra.*

It is dark. A spotlight illuminates YOUNG LAURA *who stands facing the audience. Her hands are clasped in prayer, and she holds a rosary between them.]*

YOUNG LAURA

O Heavenly Father, I call upon you. Please, send me an Angel, for I am so lonely. I do not wish to beg, but I know you can feel it. This longing- oh God- *oh God, please.*

*[*YOUNG LAURA *drops to her knees. She trembles.]*

YOUNG LAURA
[through tears]

May she come to me, and never leave, so I will never be lonely again.

[BLACKOUT.

Music swells. Lights up slowly.

YOUNG LAURA *is now asleep in her bed. She sleeps restlessly.*

A shadow stretches across the stage, like a long-fingered hand hovering over her on the bed.]

WOMAN'S VOICE
[a whisper]

Your mother warns you to beware of the assassin.

[This is unheard by YOUNG LAURA.

Silence for a moment. CARMILLA *crawls out from under the bed.* CARMILLA'S *movements are very cat-like, prowling over* YOUNG LAURA.

YOUNG LAURA *awakens again. She sits up and looks around her empty bedroom. She is startled upon seeing* CARMILLA.

They stare at each other. YOUNG LAURA's *mouth hangs open like she's trying to say something but cannot.*

YOUNG LAURA *falls back asleep.* CARMILLA *has charmed her.*

CARMILLA *bares her fangs near* YOUNG LAURA's *clavicle before-*

YOUNG LAURA *wakes with a scream*. CARMILLA *slinks back underneath the bed.*

MADAME PERRODON *and* LAFONTAINE *rush in.]*

MADAME PERRODON

What is it dear? Did you have a bad dream?

YOUNG LAURA

No Madame! It was a woman! She hid herself under the bed- look, look!

*[*FATHER *enters].*

YOUNG LAURA

Papa!

FATHER

What's happened? What's got you so frightened?

*[*MADAME PERRODON *looks under the bed. Nothing. She looks at* FATHER *and shakes her head*. LAFONTAINE *keeps looking.*

FATHER *sits beside* YOUNG LAURA *and holds her close.]*

FATHER

It's okay... It was just a dream.

YOUNG LAURA

It was not, papa! She was just there- on me like a great cat!

FATHER

There is no one under the bed, my darling.

LAFONTAINE

[whispering to MADAME PERRODON]

Lay your hand along that hollow in the bed; someone *did* lie there, so sure as you did not; it is still warm.

YOUNG LAURA

I saw her, papa!

FATHER

No one could have come in here but us.

YOUNG LAURA

What if it was my angel?! Disguised as a monster!

FATHER

Nonsense. It was just a dream. Angels do not frighten us, my love. They bring peace.

*[*FATHER *strokes* YOUNG LAURA'S *hair. She relaxes just slightly.*

FATHER *stands.]*

FATHER

You both may go.

MADAME PERRODON

[whispering to FATHER]

You saw how frightened she was. Perhaps it's worth locking the windows or setting the dogs to patrol the grounds.

FATHER

She'll be fine. I will speak to her in the morning.

[FATHER kisses YOUNG LAURA on the forehead.]

FATHER

Sleep now, my darling. No one will hurt you.

*[*FATHER *leads* MADAME PERRODON *and* LAFONTAINE *out of the room.*

YOUNG LAURA *lies back down, curled up.]*

YOUNG LAURA

[whispering]

O Heavenly Father, watch over me throughout the night and keep me safe from harm.

*[*YOUNG LAURA *repeats this prayer until she falls back asleep as the lights fade.*

Sounds of wind that will continue into the next scene.]

S C E N E T W O
A G U E S T

[AT RISE: The Drawing Room. There is a couch, a lounge chair, and a small coffee table. The lighting is warm as if there were a fireplace.

It is dark. Spotlight on LAURA*, now 8 years older. She holds a journal. She looks at it open, and closes it. She looks toward the audience as if she is speaking to them as her journal.]*

LAURA

[to audience]

In Styria, we, though by no means magnificent people, inhabit a castle, or *schloss,* tucked away in the wilderness, many miles from civilization. My life has been, I confess, one of seclusion. But I experienced an adventure that has left a mark which, I believe, will never fade. *[Pause]*

The years passed, though they did little to erase the memory of that strange dream I had as a child- the dream which was not a dream. In it, I saw a woman, my Carmilla, my angel of death.

[The sound of wind intensifies. LAURA *looks back, toward the dark, as if looking into her past.]*

LAURA

[to audience]

I must tell you now, how very small is the party who constitute the inhabitants of our castle. My father and I are the only family within it, my mother, a Styrian lady, died in my infancy, but I had a good-natured governess, whom has been with me as long as I can remember.

I tell you this because, the day my angel showed up at our door, it was like any other; lonely and unremarkable.

[Lights fade. Music plays.

Lights up.

LAURA *sits in the chair, her journal open on her lap.* FATHER *enters with an open letter in hand.]*

LAURA

Papa! Are our guests arriving soon? I cannot wait to welcome another young lady to the schloss!

FATHER

Doctor Spielsdorf cannot come to us so soon as I had hoped.

LAURA

Why not? How soon will they come?

FATHER

Not till autumn. Not for two months, I dare say. *[pause]* And I am very glad now, dear, that you never knew his daughter well…

LAURA

And why?

FATHER

Because the poor young lady is dead.

*[*LAURA *sits up, shocked.]*

LAURA

Dead!?

FATHER

I quite forgot I had not told you, but you were not in the room when I received the letter this evening.

LAURA

Well, what happened, papa? I know he wrote some weeks ago that she was not so well as he would wish her, but there was nothing to suggest the remotest suspicion of danger!

FATHER

Here is his letter. I am afraid he is in great affliction; the letter appears to have been written very nearly in distraction.

*[*LAURA *looks at the letter.* FATHER *takes a seat.]*

LAURA

[reading aloud]

My dearest old friend… I cannot offer much couth in my words, for I am utterly undone.

*[*SPIELSDORF *joins in here in a VOICEOVER.]*

LAURA

I have lost my darling daughter, for as such I loved her.

SPIELSDORF

I have lost my darling daughter, for as such I loved her.

SPIELSDORF

During the last days of dear Berthe's illness I was not able to write to you. Before then I had no idea of her danger. I have lost her, and now learn *all* too late. She died in the peace of innocence. The fiend who betrayed our infatuated hospitality has done it all. I thought I was receiving into my house innocence, gaiety, a charming companion for my lost Berthe. Heavens! what a fool have I been! I thank God my child died without a suspicion of the cause of her sufferings. I devote my remaining days to tracking and extinguishing a monster. I am told I may hope to accomplish my righteous and merciful purpose. Sometime in the autumn, two months hence, or earlier if I live, I will see you- that is, if you permit me…

LAURA

…I will then tell you all that I scarce dare put upon paper now. Farewell. Pray for me, dear friend.

FATHER

I cannot fathom the loss of a child, but he sounds like he's gone mad.

LAURA

What does he mean, fiends and monsters?

FATHER

Greif can make people say all manner of strange things.

[Sudden woman's scream. Sound of horses. A crash. LAURA *startles.]*

FATHER

Stay here.

*[*FATHER *rises and moves offstage. Sound of a door opening. Heavy wind and rain.*

FATHER *reenters alongside The* COUNTESS*. The two of them supporting* CARMILLA*, who is injured and trembling. She looks barely conscious. They lay her on the couch.]*

LAURA

What's happened!?

FATHER

A carriage has overturned, just off the summit of the bridge!

THE COUNTESS

Please help her! Oh, my dear girl!

*[*FATHER *places his fingers on* CARMILLA's *wrist, checking her pulse.]*

FATHER

I fancy myself something of a physician. Her pulse, though faint and irregular, is undoubtedly distinguishable. She will live. Please, my lady, sit and rest yourself for a moment while we care for your daughter.

THE COUNTESS

Who else could be so cursed with calamity? Here I am, on a journey of life and death, where even an hour lost could mean losing everything.

LAURA

[to audience]

Now, this accident proved much less serious than it appeared. The Countess' men made easy work of righting the carriage and calming the horses. The only true concern was for my Carmilla, who was most definitely stunned, but certainly not dead.

THE COUNTESS

My poor girl! She is in no state to continue, and I haven't the faintest idea how long it will take for her to recover. But I cannot stay. I cannot. My husband waits for me, and our business cannot delay. Sir, how far is the nearest village? I must leave her there, though it breaks my heart.

FATHER

But surely-

THE COUNTESS

What else can I do? It tears at me, but I have no option! She is my heart, my soul! But to stop now would risk far more than you could ever know.

*[*LAURA *tugs on* FATHER's *sleeve and leans in close to him.]*

LAURA

Oh! Ask her to let the lady stay with us- it would be so wonderful! Please, papa!

*[*FATHER *considers for a moment.]*

FATHER

Madame, if you'd entrust your child to the care of my daughter and her governess, Madame Perrodon, and allow her to remain here as our guest, it would be an honor. I promise we'll treat her with all the care and devotion such a responsibility deserves.

THE COUNTESS

I can't do that, sir. I do not know you. You must understand, it will be months before I am able to return. It would be asking too much of your kindness.

FATHER

On the contrary, it would be doing us a great kindness at a time when we truly need it. My daughter has just been disappointed by a cruel misfortune, in a visit from which she had long anticipated a great deal of happiness. This would be the perfect way to lift her spirits. The nearest village is far, and has no inn that would be safe for your daughter if she is as fragile as you say. If you truly cannot delay your journey, then trust us to care for her. There's no safer place for her to rest than here.

[The COUNTESS *looks down at her daughter, dismissively, not affectionately. She then beckons to* FATHER*, who follows her upstage. She whispers in his ear.*

The COUNTESS *returns to* CARMILLA*. She whispers in her ear.*

The COUNTESS *exits, wordlessly.*

Lights fade. Spotlight on LAURA*.]*

LAURA

[to audience]

When the door shut and the Countess disappeared into the night, for a brief moment it felt as if the entire thing had been a dream. This was the most commotion the castle had seen since I was a child. I wouldn't have believed it real had Carmilla not been lying there still.